

TRUTH IS RUTHLESS

The making of a modern writer with a fierce commitment to his art. The ingenuous and astonishing story of Naipaul's desperate struggles and sensational successes in a merciless world.



**THE WORLD IS WHAT IT IS:
THE AUTHORIZED BIOGRAPHY
OF V.S. NAIPAUL**
by PATRICK FRENCH
Picador India
Price: Rs 595. Pages: 555

■ By Makarand Paranjape

In 1983, at the height of his fame, in a rare moment of introspection but with compulsive candour, V.S. Naipaul wrote: "What is the truth about my situation at the age of 51? After the life of the writer, the labour entailed by the vocation, I am still as dissatisfied, as unclear, as empty as at the beginning.... So many beginnings; so many zests; so many let-downs afterwards. The solitude is the same, almost." By the early 1980s, Patrick French says that Naipaul was "at the peak of his fame". Post-World War II British fiction had not produced another author of his talent or stature. He presented himself as a "special, incomparable, unclassifiable case", "a pristine talent" with very little to do with his West Indian background, Indian past, or British present. He gave "rare", sensational interviews, which always created controversy, but protected his writing self by deflecting attention away from it.

His marriage with Pat Hale, whom he had met as an Oxford undergraduate, and who had been his companion and helper through the years, was more or less over. He discovered sexual passion somewhat late in life in Margaret, an Argentine woman of English extraction, with whom he had a tempestuous relationship for 20 years. Already a mother of three children, and nearly a foot taller than him, she became his travelling companion and lover.

Naipaul had met Margaret in April 1972 when he was in

Argentina, covering its political unrest for *The New York Review*. In 10 years, she had three abortions for him. As his biographer puts it, "a kink in his personality met a kink in hers, and snagged". He gave her almost nothing and was frequently abusive, once beating her for days till her face was swollen and his hand hurt. But she was obsessed with him, leaving her husband and children, to be his "whore". Commenting on his own brutality, Naipaul observed, "I have enormous sympathy for people who do strange things out of passion."

Meanwhile, Pat went into severe depression. Yet, she could never break with Naipaul. Whenever he needed her, she returned to tend to him, keep house, be his companion and creative

assistant. After all, it was she who had first believed in his genius, when he was penniless.

After *A Way in the World* (1994), in an interview with *Der Spiegel*, Naipaul admitted, "When I was young, you know, I was a great frequenter of prostitutes." The following year, in a longer interview to *The New Yorker*, he repeated, "I became a great prostitute man". The interview also mentioned his longstanding relationship with Margaret. Already suffering from cancer, Pat had a relapse. However, she remained loyal to him till the end by refusing to speak about his betrayals. Naipaul himself believed that this may have finally caused her death: "It could be said that I had killed her." What sustained Naipaul through all the

crises and depressions of his life? It was his vocation as a writer. As French puts it, "He would sacrifice anything or anybody that stood in the way of his central purpose, to be 'the writer'." Fragile, narcissistic, but driven by this singular ambition, Naipaul maintained the "idea of his own singularity".

In a way, the world has agreed with his self-assessment. It has heaped every possible award and honour on him, including a knighthood, the highest literary prizes, fame, success, and after Pat's death, a second Lady Naipaul, the Pakistani Nadira.

In addition to "his projected destiny" in which he had absolute faith, the other quality that distinguishes Naipaul from many other great writers is his unfailing regard for truth. "I am a great believer in the record, that the truth is wonderful and that any doctored truth is awful." This in Naipaul comes closest to Mahatma Gandhi, whom he grudgingly admired and wrote about so often. Naipaul avoided doctoring anything in this

THE SINGULAR
MAN: Naipaul

